NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.
1NT Opening: 15-17 points
2NT Opening: 20-21 points
1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit
2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.
In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.
Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥K

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 6NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♦10

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: South
Lead: ♣J

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 6♥
Declarer: West
Lead: ♣Q

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♠5

Board: 6
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 6♥
Declarer: East
Lead: ♠Q

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

♠ 8 4
♥ A 8 7 2
♦ A 9 6 4
♣ A K Q

♠ Q J 9 5
♥ J 4
♦ K 10 8 2
♣ J 7 3



♠ 10
♥ K Q 10 9
♦ Q J 5 3
♣ 9 5 4 2

♠ A K 7 6 3 2
♥ 6 5 3
♦ 7
♣ 10 8 6

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2♥
Pass	2♠	Pass	3♠
Pass	4♠		
All Pass			

4♠ by North
Lead: ♥K

Partner's 2♥ bid is a transfer; you respond 2♠. Partner now bids 3♠.

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You wouldn't have chosen ♠s for a trump suit.

But you aren't doing the choosing, partner is. He has set the trump suit as ♠s and asks that you bid game if you have a maximum 1NT opening. So you bid 4♠, as instructed.

North plays 4♠. East leads ♥K, West plays ♥J. You have no reason to hold up so you win the ♥A.

Loser List: ♠ = ? : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = ?

Things look simple. You can afford one ♠ loser so as long as they split 3-2 you will succeed. So you play ♠A, ♠K; East follows to the first and discards a ♦ on the second.

OK, West has two trump tricks, but don't give up. Maybe, just maybe, there is a way out. Check your winners:You have won 3 tricks - ♥A and ♠ A K. You have 4 more top winners - ♦A and ♣ A K Q. If you can somehow add 3 more small trumps that will be the 10 you need.

Play dummy's ♦7 to your ♦A, then ruff a ♦. Play a ♣ to your hand and ruff another ♦. Play another ♣ to your hand and ruff your last ♦. While you are ruffing these three ♦s West is helplessly following suit.

Now play to your good ♣ while West again has to follow suit.

You have taken the first 10 tricks. Poor West is going to end up ruffing his partner's ♦ winner with one of his master trumps.

Trumps don't always split as evenly as you would like them to.

When they split badly, sometimes you can recover by ruffing with small trumps while the trump-heavy defender has to follow suit.

This is called "trump elopement".

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ 10 9 4 2 ♥ J 10 4 3 ♦ 5 4 ♣ 10 8 5	
♠ 8 7 6 ♥ Q 8 5 ♦ A J 2 ♣ K Q J 3		♠ A K J ♥ A 7 2 ♦ K Q 7 6 ♣ A 9 4
	♠ Q 5 3 ♥ K 9 6 ♦ 10 9 8 3 ♣ 7 6 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		2NT	Pass
6NT			
All Pass			

6NT by East
Lead: ♦10

Sometimes bidding is easy. Partner has 20 or 21 points, balanced. You have 13 points, balanced. Total = 33 or 34 points, balanced. So you close your eyes and bid 6NT.

The contract would be 6NT played by West.

East plays 6NT. South leads the ♦10. Too bad South didn't lead a ♠. Oh, well.

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 4 : ♣ = 4 :: Total = 11

There is no way to get more than 4 winners in each minor suit, so you need to win either the ♠J or ♥Q.

Which one should you try?

Why not try both? If you make sure you try them in the right order you can have both chances.

Suppose you lead a small ♠ from dummy and play your ♠J, and it loses to South's ♠Q. If you then try leading a small ♥ toward dummy's ♥Q, obviously the defender with the ♥K will grab it to set the contract.

Instead, try the effect of leading toward the ♥Q first. If South has the ♥K then you will succeed in creating the extra winner you need. But what if you play the ♥Q and North takes it with his ♥K? Too bad, but at least you are not dead yet. You still have a chance to finesse North for the ♠Q.

Here is an important principle. There are two critical cards, the ♠Q and the ♥K. However they are not the same degree of criticality.

If the ♠Q is in a favorable position, (with North), you are always going to make your contract no matter which you try first.

But if only the ♥K is in a favorable position, (with South), you can make the contract only if you try ♥s first.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

♠ 7 4 2
♥ K Q J 6 5
♦ 7 3
♣ A 8 3

♠ 9 6 3
♥ A 10 9 8
♦ A Q 5
♣ J 10 9



♠ 10 8 5
♥ 3
♦ K 10 9 2
♣ 7 6 5 4 2

♠ A K Q J
♥ 7 4 2
♦ J 8 6 4
♣ K Q

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	2♦	Pass	2♥
Pass	3NT	Pass	4♥
All Pass			

4♥ by South
Lead: ♣J

Partner's 2♦ bid is a transfer; you respond 2♥. Partner now bids 3NT.

Partner's 2♦ bid is a transfer; you respond 2♥. Partner now bids 3NT.

Partner tells you that he has enough points to be in game, and that he holds exactly 5 ♥s. With your 3 ♥s you know of an 8-card Major fit so you correct the contract to 4♥.

South plays 4♥. West leads the ♣J. You win the opening lead with your ♣Q.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = ? : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = ?

The 2 ♦ losers are unavoidable, and even you will have to give up a trick to the Ace of trumps. So you have to make sure not to lose a second ♥.

Win the ♣Q and play a small ♥ to dummy's ♥J, which holds the trick.

I hope you didn't continue drawing trumps by playing the ♥K. If you did then you are going down in an ice-cold contract.

The way to lose only one ♥ trick is to keep leading toward dummy's honors. So come to your hand with a black card and play another ♥ in that direction, leading through West's ♥A. When you win that trick repeat the maneuver.

It is really against the odds for West to hold ♥ A 10 9 x. In fact it would only occur perhaps one time in seven.

But there is no reason to go down once every seven times when you don't need to.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ 8 7 6 3 ♥ 9 4 ♦ 10 5 2 ♣ Q J 10 4	
♠ Q 4 ♥ K 8 6 2 ♦ K Q J 3 ♣ A 7 5	N W E S	♠ A K J 5 ♥ A J 10 5 ♦ A 6 4 ♣ 8 3
	♠ 10 9 2 ♥ Q 7 3 ♦ 9 8 7 ♣ K 9 6 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1NT	Pass	2♣	Pass
2♥	Pass	6♥	
All Pass			

6♥ by West
Lead: ♣Q

The 2♣ bid was Stayman, so you bid your ♥s.

Partner takes the direct approach and puts you in slam.

West plays 6♥. North leads the ♣Q. North finds their best lead, exposing your ♣ loser right off the bat.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 2

If you can guess the ♥ finesse correctly you will make 7, discarding dummy's ♣ loser on the fourth ♦. But if you guess wrong they will immediately set you with a ♣ trick.

There is a better way - one that combines two chances. Win the ♣A. Then play your ♥A and ♥K. If the ♥Q happens to fall, pull the last trump and run your winners.

If the ♥Q **DOESN'T** fall, (she won't of course), switch to ♦s. On the fourth round of ♦s discard dummy's ♣, whether it is ruffed with the ♥Q or not.

If you knew to play the South for the ♥Q then you wouldn't need this improved plan.

But playing the deal as described will win whenever the ♥Q is doubleton, **OR** when the player with the protected ♥Q holds at least 3 ♦s.

Pretty good odds, better than the going rate for finesses, which is 50% off.

There was an alternate plan, just as good. After taking the two top trumps, run the ♠s, discarding two ♣s from your hand. As you see, either would have worked.

Board 5
North Deals
N-S Vul

♠ Q J 4
♥ Q J 3
♦ K Q J 2
♣ A J 5

♠ K 9 7
♥ 8 7 6 4 2
♦ A 9
♣ 10 8 2



♠ A 10 8 5 3
♥ K 5
♦ 8 7 4 3
♣ 9 3

♠ 6 2
♥ A 10 9
♦ 10 6 5
♣ K Q 7 6 4

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♠5

Partner's 2NT bid invites you to bid game if you have a maximum hand. You aren't thrilled by all the Quacks in your hand but with 17 points you bid 3NT.

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♠5. West wins the first trick with the ♠K and returns the ♠9. East plays the ♠3 under your ♠J.

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 5 :: Total = 7

You need 2 more tricks, and the ♦ suit will provide them after you drive out the ♦A.

Is that what you should do?

That is definitely **NOT** what you should do. East led the ♠5, then played the ♠3 to the second trick. You have seen the ♠4 and ♠2 so it is clear that East started with a 5-card suit. That means West still has a ♠. The instant you play a ♦ one of the defenders will grab the ♦A and East will take his three more ♠ tricks.

As much as you hate to put your contract in the hands of a 50% finesse chance, that is what you must do. Forget the ♦ suit and finesse East for the ♥K, trying for two extra tricks in ♥s.

East played very well to duck the second ♠, leaving his partner with a ♠ in case he could get the lead.

So you have to play well and stay away from ♦s.

Board 6
West Deals
E-W Vul

♠ 9 8 3 2
♥ 10 4
♦ 9 7 6 3
♣ K 10 5

♠ A K 5 4
♥ A 3 2
♦ Q J 10
♣ J 7 6

N
W E
S

♠ 7
♥ K Q J 9 8 7 5
♦ A
♣ A 8 4 2

♠ Q J 10 6
♥ 6
♦ K 8 5 4 2
♣ Q 9 3

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1NT	Pass	4♣	Pass
4♠	Pass	6♥	
All Pass			

6♥ by East
Lead: ♠Q

3

There would be nothing wrong with a transfer bid here, but probably no advantage either. What you really want to know is how many Aces partner has. So you ask him with a Gerber 4♣ bid.

Partner says 4♠ (2 Aces),

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Partner says 4♠ (2 Aces),

Looking at three possible ♣ losers you bid 6♥.

East plays 6♥. South leads the ♠Q. The first trick is easy; you win with dummy's ♠A.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 3 :: Total =

It can't do any good to ruff your fourth ♣ in dummy because you would have to lose two before that could happen. Of course one of your ♣s can be discarded on dummy's ♠K but what about the other two?

Suppose you win the ♠ and unblock the ♦A. Play ♥K, then to dummy's ♥A. Take one ♣ discard on the ♠K, then play the ♦Q and discard a second ♣.

It won't work. You would establish the ♦ for your last discard but you have no entry to it.

This will work. At trick 2 discard the ♦A on dummy's ♠K. Play the ♦Q and discard a ♣ when North doesn't cover. South will take the ♦K and attack ♣s but you are in control now. You win your ♣A, pull trumps, ending in dummy, and discard the remaining 2 ♣ losers on dummy's ♦ J 10.

This is called a Jettison play. You sacrifice your ♦A to unblock the suit for dummy's ♦ Q J 10.

If North held the ♦K the play would be slightly different; you would have to ruff when he covered. But the result would be the same.

Did you notice that you started with 3 ♣ losers and no ♦ loser, but you ended up losing 1 ♦ and no ♣s?